

your sleep habits to furthering your education.

Resist the urge to operate the same as before

{{< youtube "cy6WGuzArgY" >}}

Emna G., founder and CEO at Veamly, speaks with GitLab's Darren M. on a number of remote work topics: reinforcing culture, encouraging work-life harmony, remote work processes, the importance of process optimization in team productivity, and asynchronous communication.

You'll find more videos such as these in the Remote Work playlist on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.

As aptly stated in Basecamp's Handbook, there's as much to unlearn as there is to learn when it comes to thriving in a remote role.

Remote work enables a great deal of flexibility, freedom, and autonomy. It also requires adaptability when it comes to communication, and may require experimentation by the team member to reach peak enjoyment.

It can be tempting for new remote workers to simply implement tactics used in colocated spaces, but from their home or a co-working space. For example, learning to search for answers within documentation rather than tapping someone on the shoulder and asking a question.

This also applies to more nuanced aspects of work, including employee perception. Whereas working from a unique place or doing things differently may be discouraged in a colocated space, consider celebrating such diversity in a remote space.

There is more benefit to working remotely than simply losing the commute. Those new to this paradigm should give themselves permission to explore, experiment, and learn from others both on their team and on remote-centric forums.

{{% include "includes/courseragitlabremotecourse.md" %}}

What are the best resources for remote working?

We've created this extensive list of resources for remote professionals, teams, and organizations.

GitLab's library of guides to working remotely is another great resource.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/gitlab-for-remote.md

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<div class="container">
<div class="row my-5 5align-items-start">
  <div class="col-8 d-flex align-items-center">
    <div>
      <p class="h3 mb-4">With GitLab, every team in your organization can work together
in a single platform, driving business outcomes faster with complete transparency, consistency
and traceability.</p>
      <p class="h4">The DevOps Platform is here</p>
      <p>GitLab empowers organizations to collaborate efficiently and asynchronously,
while strengthening security and compliance.</p>
      <p>One system to install and maintain. End-to-end lifecycle support from one
provider. One point of integration for external systems. One user interface for the entire
lifecycle.</p>
      <p class="h4">Deliver better products faster</p>
      <p>Accelerate the software delivery process to meet business objectives.</p>
      <p>Collaborate in a single system, minimize context-switching and waiting, identify
and remove productivity blockers, and deliver more value faster with more productive, focused
developers.</p>
      <p class="h4">Reduce security and compliance risk</p>
      <p>Simplify processes to comply with internal processes, controls and industry
regulations without compromising speed.</p>
      <p>Increase reliability and performance while you grow by eliminating custom
integrations.</p>
      <p class="h4">Whether your team is fully remote, hybrid, or distributed across
multiple sites, GitLab simplifies operations and increases your efficiency. Sign up to view
demos, read use cases, and get implementation tips.</p>
    </div>
  </div>
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target="hidden-form">
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        </div>
        <div class="mb-3">
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  </div>
</div>
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</div>
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  <input class="form-check-input" type="checkbox" value="sendEmails"
id="sendEmails">
    <label class="form-check-label" for="sendEmails">
      I would like to receive emails from GitLab about its products, services and
events.
    </label>
  </div>
  <div class="mb-3">
    <button type="submit" class="btn btn-lg btn-light">Watch Now</button>
  </div>
</form>
</div>
<div id="thankyou" class="text-center align-items-center">
  <p class="h2 mb-4">Thank you for registering</p>
  <button type="button" class="btn btn-lg btn-light" data-bs-toggle="modal" data-bs-
target="videoModal">
    Watch the video again
  </button>
</div>
</div>
</div>
<div class="row my-5">
  <div class="col">
    <h2>Using GitLab for remote collaboration</h2>
    <p>GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether
they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let
software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications.
Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of
companies and roles.</p>
  </div>
</div>
<div class="row my-5">
  <div class="col d-flex align-items-center">
    <div>
      <h2>Document while you work</h2>
      <p>Instead of critical information getting lost in email or chat, writing down
what's happening inside of GitLab Issues means the plan, process, and execution are
automatically documented. Other users can be tagged to comment and collaborate. Since Issues

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are a many-to-many channel, it's easy to loop in more folks without the clutter of a reply-all thread.</p>

</div>
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<div class="col">

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<div class="row my-5">
 <div class="col">

 </div>
 <div class="col d-flex align-items-center">
 <div>
 <h2>Track work from dream to done</h2>
 <p>Adding labels to GitLab Issues lets you categorize work into different stages, such as planning, in-progress, and complete. GitLab Boards give you visibility and control over how work is being done. It's like moving digital post-it notes across an online whiteboard that everyone can use, not just the folks in the conference room.</p></div>
 </div>
 </div>

<div class="row my-5">
 <div class="col d-flex align-items-center">
 <div>
 <h2>Connect strategy to execution</h2>
 <p>GitLab Epics and Roadmaps provide a way to organize and visualize your entire portfolio of work over the long term. While Issues represent everyday tasks, Epics represent entire features or projects. Roadmaps let you plan work by seeing which work is competing for space and track progress against an assigned completion date.</p>
 </div>
 </div>
 <div class="col">

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</div>

<div class="row my-5">
 <div class="col">

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 <div class="col d-flex align-items-center">
 <div>

<h2>Version every word</h2>

<p>One of the advanced uses for GitLab is to treat copy like code. You can store, version, review, and approve not only software code, but any text at all. Using GitLab's version control and "code review" capabilities for your text-based copywriting, you'll be able to track versions, know who changed what when, make multiple proposals to the same document, and easily manage approvals.</p></div>

</div>

</div>

</div>

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<div class="modal-content">

<div class="modal-header">

<h5 class="modal-title" style="color: 000000;">GitLab for Remote Team Video</h5>

<button type="button" class="btn-close" data-bs-dismiss="modal" aria-label="Close"></button>

</div>

<div class="modal-body text-center">

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</div>

<div class="modal-footer">

<i class="fa-brands fa-youtube"></i> Watch on YouTube {{< external >}}

<button type="button" class="btn btn-lg btn-primary" data-bs-dismiss="modal"><i class="fa-solid fa-circle-check"></i> Done</button>

</div>

</div>

</div>

</div>

<script>

function getCookie(cname) {

let name = cname + "=";

let decodedCookie = decodeURIComponent(document.cookie);

let ca = decodedCookie.split(';');

for(let i = 0; i <ca.length; i++) {

let c = ca[i];

while (c.charAt(0) == ' ') {

c = c.substring(1);

}

if (c.indexOf(name) == 0) {

return c.substring(name.length, c.length);

}

}

return "";

}

```

$( document ).ready(function() {
  const registerd = getCookie("gitlab-for-remote-registered");
  if(registerd) {
    $("thankyou").show();
    $("regiserFormDiv").hide();
  }
});
$("registerForm").on("submit", function(event) {
  console.log("Triggering submit");
  $("thankyou").show();
  $("regiserFormDiv").hide();
  const videoModal = new bootstrap.Modal(document.getElementById('videoModal'));
  document.getElementById("gitlabForRemoteVideo").src =
"https://www.youtube.com/embed/qCDAioq3eis?si=ZXhlzw7wJD5XveTK"
  const d = new Date();
  d.setTime(d.getTime() + (3602460601000));
  let expires = "expires="+ d.toUTCString();
  document.cookie = "gitlab-for-remote-registered=true;" + expires + ";path=/";
  videoModal.show();
});
</script>
<style>
  thankyou {
    width: 100% !important;
    display: none;
  }
  regiserFormDiv {
    display: block;
  }
  .modal.fade .modal-dialog {
    -webkit-transition: -webkit-transform 0.3s ease-out;
    -moz-transition: -moz-transform 0.3s ease-out;
    -o-transition: -o-transform 0.3s ease-out;
    transition: transform 0.3s ease-out;
  }
</style>

```

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/handbook-first.md

{style="max-width: 50%;"}</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 785 900 868" data-label="Text">
<p>A handbook-first approach to communication is sneakily vital to a well-run business. While it feels skippable · inefficient, even · the outsized benefits of intentionally writing down and organizing process, culture, and solutions are staggering. Conversely, avoiding structured documentation is the best way to instill a low-level sense of chaos and confusion that hampers growth across the board.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 884 869 902" data-label="Text">
<p>GitLab is intentional about documenting in a manner that creates a single source of truth. It</p>
</div>

operates handbook-first, and in valuing transparency, makes its handbook publicly accessible to all.

Terminology (documentation, handbook-first, single source of truth)

The term "documentation" often refers to the process of generating documentation after a change has been communicated. At GitLab, we write things down first, and communicate that (E.g. Document the solution first, then announce via Slack or email.). This way there is no need for documentation after the communication, a step that is frequently skipped.

The goal isn't to create a culture of documenting for the sake of documenting; rather, to create an environment where net new solutions are documented in a universally accessible handbook before dissemination, and iterations are made to the universally recognized single source of truth. Each team member must approach documentation the same way, much like an editorial team adheres to a style guide.

Why does handbook-first matter?

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In early-stage startups, it's particularly tempting to avoid a documentation strategy. With only a few team members, it's feasible to keep everyone informed via meetings, Slack, or email threads. Long-term, this oversight becomes increasingly harmful.

As a team scales, the need for documentation increases in parallel with the cost of not doing it. Said another way, implementing an effective communication strategy becomes more difficult · yet more vital · as a company ages and matures.

Documentation is rarely placed on the same pedestal with metrics such as sales and client retention during a company's formative years, but it deserves to be. The difference between a well-documented company and one that eschews a handbook is stark.

A handbook-first organization is home to team members who benefit from having a single source of truth to lean on. This type of organization is able to operate with almost supernatural efficiency. An organization that does not put concerted effort into structured documentation has no choice but to watch its team members ask and re-ask for the same bits of data in perpetuity, creating a torturous loop of interruptions, meetings, and suboptimal knowledge transfers.

Start now

A top concern from established colocated or hybrid-remote organizations who wish to transition to all-remote is their tardiness in creating a company handbook. This sentiment is also shared by companies that maintain separate offices · which are remote to each other · who long to lay the groundwork necessary for teams to collaborate seamlessly.

It's important not to let hindsight thwart progress in the here and now. While an ideal time to begin a company handbook is at inception, the next best time is today.

Let your Slack or chat messages expire quickly

At GitLab, only 90 days of Slack activity is retained. After that, it's gone. This is intentional, as it prevents Slack as being useful as a tool for managing projects end-to-end. Slack, Microsoft Teams, and similar tools are instant messaging platforms, which may work to the detriment of a truly asynchronous culture.

Leaders who are serious about ensuring that their team can rely on a single source of truth will be ruthless when it comes to instant message retention. If team members know that they can search their instant message history for updates on a given project, there is no motivation to document progress in a place that is universally accessible. This creates massive knowledge gaps and further splinters communication, alignment, and understanding throughout an organization.

A limited retention policy acts as a forcing function. It nudges team members to discuss work matters in a location that is directly tied to the ultimate single source of truth. At GitLab, all work, process, and policies are documented in the handbook.

To get there, discussions begin in GitLab Issues and/or Merge Requests · not in Slack. This ensures that whatever is merged into the handbook has a proper trail, full of context and universally accessible.

Instant messaging tools are difficult to add people to a conversation, and all work history is left in that program, with no context following the work to where it eventually ends up.

It's difficult to rally an organization to only use Slack for informal communication, but it's worth the effort. Otherwise, you ensure a tortuous pattern of people pinging people for updates and snippets of information, adding further fuel to the chaotic fire that is synchronous workflows.

Don't get overwhelmed

There's a very real fear that instilling a culture of "handbook first" is too tall a task to actually accomplish. The goal should not be to complete the handbook before ever announcing its existence to the company.

For established organizations, the trick is to apply iteration to the challenge of standing up a handbook within a company. Put the proper infrastructure in place (which we'll cover below), and begin documenting process after process, one at a time. Building a handbook well after a firm's infancy is tough, as you're changing both process and culture while operating a business at scale. However, leaders can manage expectations to make the handbook's insertion easier to understand profoundly through intuition or empathy.

Documentation is never finished

Handbooks are never finished. They are evolving, living entities, and it may take months or years to feel even remotely comprehensive.

Resist the urge to abandon documentation plans when crisis hits. The most powerful documentation is that which is derived from failure. A lesson learned provides a vital roadmap

of what to avoid, and how to operate better, in the future.

Tools for building a handbook

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A common belief is that a company wiki can serve as a handbook, but the reality is that wikis do not scale. They are designed to be updated by a select few, which creates several issues. One, content frequently falls out of date, which triggers a company-wide belief that the information cannot be trusted without personally confirming with another human (and in turn, injecting inefficiency into the process of self-learning).

Two, it creates class segmentation · those entrusted to update the wiki, and those who are not yet wise or elite enough to do so.

Wikis are also highly siloed. They do not support proposals which touch multiple parts of multiple pages.

- GitLab (the company) uses GitLab (the product) to maintain and evolve its handbook, and other organizations regardless of size can do likewise. By leveraging distributed version control, anyone in the company (and even outside of the company) is empowered to put forth proposals for improvement.

Suddenly remote quick boot handbook guide

If you're looking to stand up a rudimentary handbook quickly, consider the Suddenly Remote Handbook. This is a free tool built by GitLab's Mike Terhar, and may be iterated on in the future.

The Getting Started section provides a step-by-step overview of launching the handbook, and there are several pre-filled sections based on GitLab's learnings that you're welcome to utilize, tweak, or cut.

The project that drives the sample rendering and starter template can be found [here](#).

Using GitLab to build and evolve a company handbook

GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at [GitLab's remote team solutions page](#).

Empower the entire team to evolve the handbook

Crucially, GitLab merge requests split the role of submitter and approver. There is no harm in opening your handbook up to proposals, as code owners and DRIs (directly responsible

individual) are ultimately responsible for reviewing each proposal and merging or editing and merging.

This enables anyone at the company, even those who have just joined, to propose changes and feel immediately invested in a company's culture.

Examples that showcase the power of distributed version control in the handbook:

1. In this merge request, only a portion of the initial proposal was agreed upon and merged into GitLab's handbook. However, this ensured that all pertinent parties had a voice. This also documents the thought process that went into the eventual documentation, such that context is in place for anyone to understand why these changes were made, and when.
1. By empowering all team members to make proposals, you enable new hires to offer up fresh perspectives that can benefit the company. This merge request is an example of a new hire sharing a proposal to strengthen GitLab's Onboarding Buddy checklist, and then her buddy made a proposal which was eventually merged.
1. This merge request was proposed by someone still in the onboarding phase at GitLab. The discussion threads offer visibility into how learning happens, how iteration shapes proposals, and how everyone can contribute to the handbook's evolution.

What goes in a company handbook?

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The beauty of using a tool like GitLab to build and evolve a company handbook is that you don't have to have the full table of contents mapped out in advance. Tools like Notion, and Guru can be used as well. Consider the following as an initial guide for top-level organization, but don't hesitate to deviate based on the size, scope, and needs of your firm.

1. Company / Building Blocks: This section houses policies, values, KPIs/OKRs, and cultural principles that apply to most or all departments in the organization. The suggested list below was curated by Luke Thomas in his book *The Anywhere Operating System*.
 - Founding story/history of the company
 - Mission, vision, and values
 - Who we serve (customer personas)
 - Why we are different (unique differentiators)
 - Annual goals
 - Product principles
 - How we hire
1. Groups/departments: Build the rest of the handbook out by departments (e.g. People, Engineering, Marketing, Sales, Finance, Product, Legal). This orients the reader with context of which group it primarily impacts, but does not preclude team members from one department from making handbook proposals to other departments.
 - Org structure
 - People profiles
 - Team profiles
1. The day-to-day
 - Policies
 - How we communicate

- Tools we use
- Standard operating procedures
- Monthly or quarterly goals

Most sections will be blank to begin with, and that's OK. Apply the spirit of iteration to documentation. Rather than judging a section for how light it is, praise a contributor for making it marginally better than it was prior.

Make handbook-first a value

The trick to ensuring a handbook grows continually is to instill it as a value. Team members should recognize that any answer or solution that isn't yet documented, should be documented immediately.

{{< youtube "3HHyjAV3hYE?start=581" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (Head of Remote, GitLab) and Gabe (Senior Product Manager, GitLab) talk on the topic of going slow to go fast, as well as the importance of a "handbook-first" approach to company-wide documentation.

> I think documentation has to be instilled as a value. It has to start there, and the whole leadership team in an organization has to be onboard.

>

> All of leadership needs to understand the importance of documentation · not just with lip service. A true, genuine understanding of its value. If they truly understand the value of it, they'll emanate that to their direct reports.

>

> For companies looking to transition to fully remote, a helpful step for leadership is to say: "OK, we're going to be remote-first as a start." This means that a company in transition would optimize everything in its physical office space to be remote-first. Instead of optimizing conference rooms with lots of tables, for instance, you have each employee sit in their own office and wear headsets all day. This is how you prevent remote employees from feeling disconnected and isolated.

>

> This is going slow to go fast. Lots of energy up front · you go slow · but that accelerates things dramatically a year or so down the road. · Gabe W., Senior Product Manager, GitLab

Write things down is an operating principle of Efficiency at GitLab. Team members are as likely to see merge requests put forth by e-group members as they are new hires.

Empowering the entire company to propose changes creates widespread autonomy and agency. This generates a shared responsibility to maintain the pace of documentation through a pay-it-forward mentality.

Designate scribes or a handbook editor team

Ideally, everyone feels as if they are a contributing member of a handbook's evolution. This is easier to foster when you instill "writing things down" as a value at an early stage. For scaled companies adding a handbook many years after inception, consider hiring dedicated scribes that sit on each team.

Former journalists are ideal for this type of work, as it goes well beyond transcription. Documenting notes during meetings, and converting them from Google Docs to handbook, requires a knack for storytelling as well as an understanding of what's important and what context should be added.

Consider investing in a handbook editor team that ensures the engineering framework is up to date, and that code owners are notified whenever pages go too long without an update.

These individuals come at a cost; however, this cost pales in comparison to the investment companies will make in perpetuity when paying team members to sit in meetings extracting answers that could've been documented years before.

This says nothing of the cost of institutional knowledge. Documented answers are easily ingested by new hires, including information that was documented by team members who have since moved elsewhere in their career journey.

Make it public

To whatever degree you legally can, consider making your company handbook public. Not only does GitLab do this, but outfits such as Glitch, MarsBased, and Basecamp do as well. Public handbooks lead to accountability. It's easier to let an internal wiki rot than it is a handbook which is open to the world.

This allows the public as well as companies in your industry to replicate processes and make suggestions for improvement. Remember, this doesn't mean that those who provide input have a right to feel heard or considered; it simply opens wide the gate for improvements you'd never consider in your own bubble.

This also creates a more welcoming environment for applicants and new hires. By sharing processes, culture, and strategy, your hiring teams are likely to field inbounds which are more qualified, put forth by individuals who have already investigated your company and believe that they align with your goals and mission.

Not just handbook-first... website-first is even more efficient

Where possible, it is even more efficient to post documentation directly to the website (handbook.gitlab.com, docs.gitlab.com) if customers, prospects or the wider community would benefit from the content. Marketers, product management and other content generators should challenge themselves to write content in a way that it can be a SSoT (single source of truth) for both external and internal audiences.

For example: if a topic is described on the public website, only add necessary commentary on that topic for internal GitLab audiences in the handbook with links to the SSoT on the public website.

Learn more about using handbook screenshots instead of creating a presentation in GitLab Handbook Usage.

Learn more about documentation

Learn more about the importance of documentation in the GitLab resources below.

- 1. Technical Writing handbook section
- 1. Documentation style guide
- 1. Documentation guidelines
- 1. Scaling by documenting

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Handbook-First Documentation

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation certification to receive the Remote Foundations Badge in GitLab Learn. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

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{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}
```

Contribute your lessons

Approaching documentation with unwavering intention is a challenge for all companies. If you or your organization has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/head-of-remote.md

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</div>
<div data-bbox="115 553 953 619" data-label="Text">
<p>GitLab and Darren M. pioneered the "Head of Remote" role. In the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, many organizations are transitioning to remote. Regardless of what phase they're in, or what stage they intend to embrace, GitLab has triggered a global movement of appointing a dedicated lead to evolve a company's remote fluency.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="121 636 353 651" data-label="Text">
<p>What is a Head of Remote?</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 669 913 752" data-label="Text">
<p>A Head of Remote ensures operational agility and durability as a workforce decouples business results from physical geography. It serves as a cross-functional internal consultant to evolve key pillars (e.g. learning & development, knowledge management, tooling, onboarding, and culture/informal communication) such that each function becomes more effective in a distributed setting.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 769 929 818" data-label="Text">
<p>Initially, a Head of Remote sets the tone for behavioral and cultural shifts required to embrace new models of working. Longer-term, the role may evolve to lead or support overarching workplace experience.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="121 835 450 852" data-label="Text">
<p>Why companies hire a Head of Remote</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 868 896 902" data-label="Text">
<p>As more organizations embrace remote-work variations, they are realizing that remote and remote-hybrid workforces run the risk of creating two opposing cultures and workflow defaults.</p>
</div>
```

For the organization to thrive, charting a harmonious path forward must be someone's job. Not just a part of their job, but the whole job.

Distributed work unlocks talent and productivity, but not without intentional effort. The underlying infrastructure of how a team works will change without an office as a crutch, and it requires a leader to steer teams through the shift, coordinate upskilling, and enlist new tools where appropriate.

Does your organization need a Head of Remote Work?

Senior leadership roles continue to grow as work expands, collaboration occurs across borders, and software continues to eat the world. Just as UiPath articulates the need for a Chief Automation Officer, the COVID-19 pandemic has made clear that working with remote teams is too important to leave to chance.

Organizations should consider hiring a Head of Remote. This may be titled Director of Remote Work, VP of Remote Work, Chief Remote Officer, or a variety of alternatives. Longer-term, this role may evolve into a Head of Workplace Experience, Head of Culture, or similar.

Below is a series of fundamental questions that leaders must answer when transitioning to remote. It is unlikely that an existing team will be capable of directing adequate attention to these needs without backfilling for other responsibilities. You can also take a look at Remote Work Trends.

Questions to ask a Head of Remote

Finding a leader with extensive remote experience and a history of successful business or culture transformations will be difficult. Suddenly-remote companies may consider hiring a Chief Documentarian to establish a regimented documentation strategy, and morph this role into a more encompassing one over time. Former editors and publishers may be suitable for such a role.

A sample of questions to be answered by a Head of Remote Work:

1. Who will direct training and upskilling of newly-remote managers, collect feedback on needed resources (and subsequently deploy said resources), coach them on unlearning old approaches, refine their mastery of asynchronous workflows, and motivate reports who may be oceans away?
1. Who will sit down and audit every single perk and benefit offered globally, and ensure that remote workers have equivalent benefits to those who choose to work onsite?
1. Who will lead an end-to-end tools audit, ensuring that tools which do not support asynchronous workflows are deprecated or replaced, and ensuring that existing tools are used in remote-first ways?
1. Who will create, establish, and champion your firm's documentation strategy, hiring the right team to ensure that communication voids are closed?
1. Who will coach your executives on the nuanced benefits of one or more being remote by default, sending clear signals that praise and promotion are not tied to a physical building?
1. Who will be the voice of the distributed worker, ensuring equality and belonging for those who may never step foot in a corporate office?
1. Who will be responsible for ensuring that newly-remote workers have healthy, ergonomic workspaces at home?

1. Who will ensure that learning and development principles address the challenges of remote hiring, remote interviewing, remote onboarding, remote management, remote promotions, and beyond?
1. Who will conduct an end-to-end process audit and provide structured replacements for remote-last workflows, such as a reliance on synchronous meetings for consensus gathering and collaboration?
1. Who will lead the reevaluation of company values, and subsequent editing and bolstering such that everyone understands how to treat others without the need for routine in-person contact?
1. Who will put a travel strategy in place such that in-person engagements become a core part of building company culture?
1. Who will revise your company's talent acquisition strategy, creating a clear and concise answer to "What's your stance on workplace flexibility?"
1. Who will build a visible talent brand demonstrating how remote workers are supported and included? (This will create significant sway in your Glassdoor reviews.)
1. Who will lead existing executives in transforming their expectations and ways of working, coaching them to model the unlearning of old habits and embracing new ones in transparent fashion?
1. Who will ensure that teams have the tools, direction, and coaching they need to become documentarians?
1. Who will outline a multi-year remote transformation strategy with quarterly milestones and objectives, coaching a team through iterative change and celebrating small wins along the way?
1. Who will champion your culture and values, not only to galvanize teams through a pandemic, but excite them by building a more disciplined, cohesive, asynchronous, inclusive, and diverse future?
1. Who will understand the nuances of remote and the myriad business implications beyond just today?

For an added deep dive on the topic, replete with a decision-making rubric, download the Head of Remote white paper from our friends at Remote.com and Distribute Consulting.

Remote transformation consultants

In lieu of hiring a full-time remote work leader, or as a bridge until you're able to recruit the ideal candidate, consider working with a specialty consulting firm. The below companies have extensive remote operational experience and carefully construct teams of subject matter experts to address the challenges specific to each client.

1. Distribute Consulting
1. Global Workplace Analytics
1. Remote-how

No one remote transformation will be identical to another. Some companies need a documentarian to craft a handbook, while others need more assistance on messaging and tooling. These consultancies run end-to-end audits to meet companies where they are and move them forward.

Be especially wary of working with remote experts and consultancies which did not have extensive remote work experience prior to the COVID-19 pandemic.

Companies hiring a Head of Remote

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The below is an inexhaustive list of firms who are publicly hiring · or have hired/appointed · a dedicated remote work leader since the COVID-19 pandemic. To add to this list, please create a merge request or tag @darrenmurph on Twitter.

Multitudes of firms are hiring for this role without formally posting a job description.

1. Facebook (now Meta): Director, Future of Work Movement and Director, Future of Work
1. Dropbox: Head of Virtual First and VP of Design
1. Twitter: VP of Real Estate & Workplace and Remote Experience
1. Upwork: Director of Remote Organizational Effectiveness
1. Grammarly: Head of Remote-First Hybrid
1. Okta: Head of Dynamic Work
1. LinkedIn: Vice President, Flex Work
1. VMWare: Senior Director, Collaboration and Productivity
1. Cloudflare: Head of Distributed Work
1. Quora: Remote Work HR Specialist
1. Zapier: Remote Communications Manager
1. Vistaprint/Cimpress: Manager, Remote-First
1. Hopin: Head of Remote
1. Gong: Director of Remote Work
1. MainStreet: Title TBD
1. Cleveland Clinic: Director of Remote Workforce Solutions
1. The Partnership for Public Service
1. Oyster: Head of Remote
1. Avalon Consulting Group: SVP and Director of Remote Work
1. Strata Solar: Director, Remote Operations
1. Doist: Head of Remote
1. Castor: Remote Lead
1. Atlassian: VP, Team Anywhere
1. NPR: Director, Future of Work
1. Prudential Financial: VP, Head of Capabilities for Future of Work
1. Careem: Director of Remote
1. Microsoft: Future of Work Communications
1. HP: Head of Future of Work, Collaboration, and Business Incubation
1. Chevron: Global Lead of Future of Work Strategies
1. Evonik: Head of Future of Work
1. RBC: Senior Director, Future of Work & Culture
1. Lockheed Martin: Workforce Transformation, Future of Work
1. Nationwide: Director, Future of Work
1. Procter & Gamble: Senior Director, Digital Transformation and Future of Work
1. Google: Director, Future of Work & Workforce Planning at Google
1. Target: Senior Vice President, Future of Work
1. Unilever: VP, Future of Work
1. Limeade: Head of Remote
1. Modern Health: Workplace Experience Manager
1. ADP: Principal, Future of Work
1. SAP: SVP & Chief Future of Work

1. Deloitte: Global Future of Work Leader and Future of Well-being Lead
1. The Recycling Partnership: Director of Organizational Effectiveness
1. Virgin Media O2: Head of Future Work and Workplace

What function or department does a Head of Remote sit in?

It depends. The general rule with a nascent role is to put it where the most help is needed. While People Operations may feel like the most suitable, a company's remote leader should be sat where they can exert the most cross-functional influence. The active roles above sit within People, Marketing, Communications, Finance, Real Estate, Operations, and Design · quite the eclectic mix.

- If change management linked to organizational design is the core concern, People Operations (or, more broadly, Operations) is likely a suitable location.
- If the key focus is on reducing or rearchitecting office space and changing both where and how people work, Real Estate and/or Finance is a logical option.
- If an organization has a solid level of remote fluency, a Head of Remote may thrive in Communications/Marketing, as the core responsibility will be to evangelize new ways of working both internally and externally.

Using GitLab to prepare for a Head of Remote career path

Chief Diversity Officer, Chief Automation Officer, Chief Data Officer, and Chief Experience Officer are all relatively new C-suite titles. Yet, it's difficult to imagine progressive organizations scoffing at the validity of their existence. GitLab has pioneered a nascent role in Head of Remote · a senior leader dedicated to remote work and workplace experience.

While case studies through Harvard Business School and INSEAD are percolating through the university system and equipping MBA students with information on running an all-remote company, there is no well-defined career path to becoming a Head of Remote.

Below are several recommended areas of study that will prepare you for a remote leadership career, paired with GitLab courses to share on your resume/CV and LinkedIn profile.

1. Master of Business Administration (MBA)
 1. Industrial/Organizational Psychology
 1. Organizational Design
 1. Organizational Change
 1. Organizational/Workplace Communication

Courses and certifications in remote work leadership

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At GitLab, we seek to open source our mastery of remote work in order to equip and empower the next generation of remote work leaders. We encourage those aspiring to fill remote work leadership roles to complete the coursework below and implement GitLab's proven practices into your current organization. In interviews, share completion of these courses and examples of implementing GitLab principles as a means to substantiate your mastery of remote work

fundamentals.

1. GitLab's Remote Work Foundations Certification
1. Remote Team Management (hosted on Coursera)

Prior to the COVID-19 pandemic, there was low supply and low demand for dedicated remote work leadership. In the midst of the pandemic, demand began to rise slowly, while supply remains low.

By 2022, most of the world's organizations will reckon with their new reality: at least a portion of their workforce will insist on more flexibility, and a refusal to adapt will lead to their best talent fleeing to organizations which are actively empowering people to work more flexibly.

> Sid Sijbrandij on Twitter/X

>

> Below is a thread about the future of remote work after the COVID-19 pandemic is over. I predict that remote will go through a trough of sorrow due to hybrid not working out, and most companies will return to being office based. But many all remote companies will see success.

As this occurs, many organizations will ignore our warnings on the pitfalls and nuanced difficulties in creating a thriving hybrid-remote organization, triggering an acute spike in demand for senior leadership who understand the mind of a remote worker and the organizational design principles to convert remote work from a challenge to a strategic advantage. In a high demand/low supply environment, remote work mastery will become a highly marketable skill.

Much like someone who is multilingual, an individual who has completed GitLab's Remote Work Foundations certification and Remote Team Management course on Coursera will have an advantage when vying for new roles centered on remote work leadership. You will effectively speak a new and evolving business language which is critical to acquiring/retaining talent, creating workflows which are location agnostic, and building a culture which does not rely on a physical building to function.

Skills and talents necessary to be a Head of Remote

While each organization will utilize a remote leader somewhat uniquely, below are skills worth honing and highlighting when pitching yourself as a Head of Remote to your existing organization, or putting yourself forward as a candidate for an open role.

Study the links below. They point to various educational sections within the GitLab handbook which will equip you with knowledge to pass the aforementioned certifications.

1. The ability to communicate with low-context and high precision, particularly with the written word
1. Deep empathy and an ability to relate to challenges from team members across the globe (Manager of One)
1. A default to servant leadership, capable of triaging and defining solutions from inbound feedback
1. Expert storytelling skills to generate understanding and organizational buy-in for significant change management campaigns (High Output Management)

1. Organizational savvy and the ability to garner influence to positively impact the working lives of team members
1. A native visionary and problem solver who seeks outside perspectives, tools, and workflows to continually evolve an organization's workplace design, culture, and strategy
1. Propensity to form and foster interdepartmental relationships
1. A default to working transparently and with a low level of shame is vital given the extreme cross-functional nature of the role
1. A sound advisor to other executives, guiding decisions through a global and inclusive lens
1. Appreciation for self-learning and self-service
1. Appreciation for documentation and knowledge taxonomy/codification
1. Proven ability to work asynchronously and coach others to do so

Head of Remote job description

We are collecting publicly available Head of Remote (or similarly titled) job descriptions in a shared Google Doc.

For companies who are attempting to articulate what they need in a remote leader, use the examples above as a starting point.

Who created the Head of Remote role?

Sid Sijbrandij and Darren M. used GitLab to create the Head of Remote role on 2019-10-26. There's a pretty good story behind it, too.

Following a "Making Remote Work" event in San Francisco, which was co-hosted by GitLab and General Catalyst, Darren M. (@darrenmurph), Sid Sijbrandij (@sytses), and Andreas Klinger (@andreasklinger) were discussing Darren's role at GitLab.

At the time, Andreas was the de facto Head of Remote Products at AngelList. After hearing Darren's duties, he informed Sid that Darren's title should be "Head of Remote" to be indicative of his responsibilities. He then tweeted the same sentiment, which is embedded below.

Sid went back to his home and created a merge request on GitLab which proposed the title change, also tweeting it for the public to follow. Darren later merged the MR, ushering the proposal into reality.

What does a Head of Remote do?

GitLab Head of Remote Darren M. details his role in an all-remote organization in his README, which serves as an operating manual to working with him.

More broadly, a Head of Remote exists to achieve the following.

1. Audit and pressure test all existing workflows, policies, and cultural underpinnings to ensure that they are adapted for remote-first
1. Serve as a trusted advisor and steerer to existing workstream leads, ensuring that their work is inclusive of geographies and time zones and accelerates the mission of all work being achievable regardless of one's physical location

1. Advise existing executives on proven remote work practices and lead a systematic unlearning process to replace old habits (e.g. defaulting to a meeting, forgoing documentation, working in silos vs. transparently, etc.) with more progressive ones
1. Evolve thinking and operations to suit the modern-day reality of workplace expectations
1. Deconstruct colocated office norms and rebuild workflows/culture to suit a vastly more opportunistic virtual work environment

If you are employed in an organization with leadership who assumes that they can manage all of the above on their own, without making investments or changes, send them the link to this section. Please tag me on Twitter (@darrenmurph) if you'd like.

Join the Head of Remote forum

We've created a space for remote leaders to share resources, challenges, and insight. Whether you're leading the remote transformation within your organization or you're seeking to pursue this as a career path, join the conversation (no longer available) in our Head of Remote forum.

Is this a real movement backed by data?

T3 Advisors

T3 Advisors reports a sharp surge in companies creating remote work leadership roles, rising from just 2% in August 2020 to 12% in November 2020.

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Initialized Capital

Survey data analyzed by Kim-Mai Cutler, a partner at Initialized Capital, shows a staggering shift to remote-first in an article entitled Post-Pandemic Silicon Valley Isn't A Place.

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> Pre-pandemic, the Bay Area was still the leading choice for our founders in terms of where to start a company. There were many other cities that were distant seconds or thirds including New York and Seattle.

>

> Post-pandemic is a different story. More than 40 percent of founders say that the best place to start a company will be in the cloud. We expect to see decentralized or remote companies displace venture-backed companies based in the Bay Area over time.

>

> Post-pandemic, the Bay Area will be the second leading technology hub after the cloud.

Capgemini Research Institute

Capgemini Research Institute surveyed 500 organizations and 5,000 employees from a range of sectors globally and conducted interviews with academicians and executives to compile its Future of Work report.

> Around three in ten organizations expect more than 70% of their employees working remotely in the next two to three years, up from just one in ten before COVID-19.

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In the news

The below is an inexhaustive list of news articles covering the growing movement of firms hiring a dedicated leader for remote work. Some of the articles may require a paid subscription to access.

- 1. The Australian: Why hybrid workplaces bring a whole new set of challenges (reproduction)
- 1. Forbes: The Next In-Demand Job Title: Head Of The Future Of Work
- 1. Protocol: Do you need to hire a 'head of remote?'
- 1. NPR Marketplace: Why more companies are hiring heads of remote work
- 1. Quartz: Five telltale signs you need a 'chief remote officer'
- 1. The New York Times: 'Head of Team Anywhere,' and Other Job Titles for an Uncertain Time
- 1. Fast Company: More companies are hiring a 'director of remote work'
- 1. San Francisco Chronicle: Tech's hottest job title in 2021? 'Head of remote work'
- 1. Digiday: 'Change without story is a mandate, change with story is purpose': Why marketing and comms execs are being tapped for chief-of-remote roles
- 1. Washington Post: Why 'head of remote' is likely to be a job title of the future
- 1. The Chartered Institute of Marketing: Is "head of remote" a marketer's next career choice?
- 1. Crowe Global: Exclusive Q&A With GitLab's Head Of Remote
- 1. Ladders: The dawn of the age of Chief Remote Work Officers
- 1. Fortune: Why GitLab hired a 'head of remote' before the Coronavirus pandemic
- 1. The Economist: The three new executive roles that define 2020
- 1. The Globe and Mail: Chief remote working officers are now navigating organizations into a post-pandemic world
- 1. SHRM: Why You Need a Remote-Work Leader
- 1. VentureBeat: After embracing remote work in 2020, companies face conflicts making it permanent
- 1. The Australian: Why hybrid workplaces bring a whole new set of challenges (subscription required)
- 1. LinkedIn Talent Blog: Why You Need to Hire a Head of Remote Work · and What That Job Entails
- 1. Reworked: Is Now the Time to Invest in a Head of Remote Work?
- 1. Running Remote: Is it time for your company to hire a Head of Remote?
- 1. Zenefits: Why Companies Are Hiring a Head of Remote Work (and Why You Should, Too)
- 1. Fast Company: Why your business needs a Head of Remote

Contribute your lessons

Making remote work well, particularly in companies with colocated roots, is a shared challenge. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/hiring.md

Remote hiring, explained

The pandemic forced many organizations to transition to be all-remote companies. Many realized the benefits and decided to keep the remote structure. This shift necessitates implementing a remote hiring process to grow a remote workforce.

As one of the world's largest all-remote companies, GitLab has been hiring and onboarding remote workers, remotely for over a decade. We've detailed what we learned in the Principles of Hiring section of our Handbook. On this page, we're sharing best practices for a streamlined remote hiring process anyone can implement.

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What are the benefits of all-remote hiring?

One advantage of being an all-remote company is the ability to hire talent from a global pool, giving access to a tremendous amount of talent that many other companies overlook.

It can be a struggle for organizations to find, recruit, retain, and compensate employees in competitive markets, including most major cities. Imagine the influx of highly qualified applicants if the location requirement were removed from all job descriptions. For a glimpse at what this looks like, please visit GitLab's Jobs page.

In addition to giving your organization a competitive edge, here are some other advantages:

- Remote hiring supports a stronger and more diverse candidate pool

All-remote hiring widens the talent pool and allows you to hire from any countries where you have legal status. This can greatly improve your company's cultural diversity. Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging (DIB) has been fundamental to GitLab's success, and we strongly encourage prioritizing DIB in hiring practices.

GitLab strives to hire team members who are passionate, empathetic, kind, tenacious, and ambitious, regardless of their location. By opening the talent acquisition funnel to as broad a swath of the world as we can, we create a more inclusive hiring environment, lean on tight collaboration to drive progress across time zones, and focus our hiring decisions on results rather than location.

- Remote hiring is a quicker process

Because you don't have to organize travel or schedule around multiple calendars, remote testing

and meeting speeds up the applicant search, narrowing, and interview process. You can asynchronously circulate recorded interviews and solicit feedback from team members unable to attend the interview.

- Remote hiring saves time and money

Cutting travel cuts considerable costs, making remote testing and interviewing highly cost-effective. I can also be less disruptive to end the process with candidates who are not a good fit at any point, without the guilt of wasting the candidate's or the company's time or money.

Hiring an all-remote team from across the globe allows GitLab to pay local rates, which you can learn more about on the company blog. By hiring brilliant minds in locations with lower costs of living, GitLab is able to save money to hire even more people as we scale our business.

- Remote hiring gives you an authentic virtual engagement experience

Remote interviews for remote jobs enable you to gauge a person's ability to communicate and interact onscreen, providing insight into how they will handle the virtual communication required in a remote role.

What to do before starting the remote hiring process

Commit to supporting remote work, not just allowing it

Supporting remote work is different than allowing it. Before hiring for a remote role, ensure that it is set up to be successful. Prepare management with training on how to be a great remote manager.

Prepare a well-designed remote interview process to ensure that you'll hire the right person and that they'll be prepared with accurate expectations.

Advertise accurately and transparently

We've published our hiring process, including example screening questions, in our handbook.

While this may be unique, we see it as simply staying true to our transparency value. The process shouldn't be a mystery.

Letting candidates know what to expect allows them to focus on whether the role and the company are right for them, while we evaluate that too.

In this GitLab Unfiltered video, GitLab's Head of Remote speaks with Remotefit co-founder Javier on building and sustaining culture while being open about processes in the talent acquisition and hiring process.

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> To be transparent, we showcase our culture to prospective hires in advance. For example, there's a section of our Jobs FAQ called "What's it like to work at GitLab?"

>

> You cannot expect to hire people who are passionate about executing your strategy if you wait to share the plan after they are onboard. Some candidates may opt out of the interview funnel if they realize they aren't a good fit for the company's mission, vision, and values.

>

> It's silly to think that a company would withhold its strategy, culture, or workflows until after someone gets hired. These elements determine whether a team member will thrive. Why would you hold that back? · Darren Murph, Head of Remote at GitLab

In this GitLab Unfiltered video, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij discusses hiring (amongst other topics) with researchers from INSEAD.

{{< youtube "EuGsen3FxxC?start=2493" >}}

> "A company might claim, 'Our strategy is very important, and you need to be aligned to it! We'll only tell you after you join.'

>

> I think that's bananas. That's what every company in the world does. If your strategy is really important, make sure people buy in before they join. And make sure that people who don't buy in don't join the company.

>

> Execution depends on people; being public about what we do. allows us to attract the best people to best execute our strategy." · GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij

Make yourself attractive to top talent

Remote work is the last great competitive advantage for employers. Remote maximizes a person's freedom and autonomy to integrate work into their life instead of the other way around. If two employers offer a talented applicant the same title, salary, and benefits, the tipping point will be the employer that supports remote work.

We've gathered extra ways to attract top talent to your organization (Note: this list assumes a workplace supports remote and permission to play behaviors.)

1. Benefits for families and caregivers (daycare stipend, cleaning/laundry stipend, meal stipend, enhanced health insurance options, continuing education, adoption/fertility support, etc.)

1. No ask, must tell vacation policy which senior leaders visibly model

1. The ability to expense a "third space" for working · an external office, coworking space, or residential community space through the likes of Codi

1. Caregiver leave (maternity, paternity, eldercare, etc.)

1. De-location stipend (supporting relocation away from a high cost-of-market location)

1. 4-day workweek, Summer Fridays, no-meeting days, and other efforts that provide company-wide time off for employees to rest, recharge, and connect with community

1. Supporting the purchase of a complete and ergonomic remote workspace uniquely tailored to each team member

1. Transparent policies for investing in and championing diversity, inclusion & belonging (and published goals for improvement)
1. Restricted stock units (RSU) or stock options
1. Enhanced hiring bonuses and higher salaries
1. Large annual bonuses based on performance (remote work measures impact, not activity, input, or time-in-seat)
1. Well-trained remote managers that default to asynchronous workflows (Confidently assuring prospective talent that they will endure fewer meetings and micromanagement is a solid way to differentiate from other employers.)
1. Publishing supportive policies which explicitly allow employees to create better work/life harmony and put family and friends before work
1. Supporting (via time and money) learning for self-development
1. Building and explicitly publishing a culture of trust, empowerment, and autonomy for employees to do great work regardless of location (view GitLab's guide on building culture and its Values page for more)
1. Engage and respect existing employees, empowering them to become talent brand ambassadors on platforms such as Glassdoor, LinkedIn, Twitter, and Comparably
1. Permit open sourcing some of an employee's work and encourage building of their personal brands
1. Clear opportunities for growth and professional development

What to do during the remote hiring process

Source for remote-work qualities

Not everyone is suited for remote work. There can be many reasons why a remote job isn't right for an individual, based on their career stage, their working preferences, or what they hope to get out of their next role.

However, there are plenty of people who thrive in remote jobs (as GitLab's global team can attest). In our 10+ years of remote hiring, here are the qualities we've learned to seek out.

Self-management

There are nuances to loving remote work and being a great remote worker. An operating principle at GitLab calls it being a "manager of one".

Communication skills

GitLab is an asynchronous company. Much of what we do is communicated through text. People with lengthy in-office careers, who default to verbal communication, may be uncomfortable communicating via text at first.

How do you screen for text-communication skills? Whether they realize it or not, most people have worked remotely. If your company has multiple locations, there's a good chance you worked with people outside of your office.

Remote-work experience

If someone has not worked in a remote environment, chances are that they have worked outside of

their office (e.g., working while traveling, advancing a university project while away from campus, etc.) Ask candidates for examples of how they managed those instances, looking specifically for how they embrace autonomy and blameless problem solving.

Even if your company didn't define it this way, those offices were remote to one another. You had to navigate Zoom calls, time zone differences, etc. For example, you may be based in Seattle with colleagues in Singapore and London. Asking applicants to dive into those situations will help uncover how they handle remote work.

Aligns with company values

Look for ways candidates align with company values. Share them in advance and ask the candidates to explain which values resonate with them and why.

Having prior experience working remotely is appreciated, but even more are attributes like timeliness, dependability, respect, a heart for collaboration, perseverance, empathy, kindness, and ambition.

Self-awareness

Self-awareness and agile thinking are required to thrive in an all-remote setting. One way to screen for this is to test a candidate's ability to perform thinking writing, as described in this Hacker News thread. Thinking writing is the ability to draft ideas, then read them, modify them, change their order, remove some, refine/add others, and share with everyone through a low level of shame.

Other qualities unique to a remote workplace are:

- 1. Inclination for self-learning and self-service
- 1. Appreciation for documentation
- 1. Proven ability to be a manager of one
- 1. Capable of (and enjoys) working asynchronously

When asked if anyone could learn to work well in an all-remote setting during an INSEAD case study interview, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij replied:

> "What's essential in all-remote is that you are a manager of one.
>
> You're not going to have someone expecting you at the office and hold your hand, so you have to be able to manage yourself and work independently.
>
> It is critical that you can write well · be concise and precise in your written communication- to bridge time zones and leverage asynchronous communication". · GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij

Tips for interviewing all-remote candidates

We've created a guide on How to Conduct a Remote Interview, and included some highlights below.

The top 10 questions to ask a remote candidate

The full list of questions to ask a remote candidate is here, but these are the most insightful:

1. What challenges have you faced working remotely, and how did you overcome them?
1. What methods do you use to ensure you are communicating with a remote team?
1. Have you ever worked independently without direct, daily supervision?
1. What strategies, tools, routines, or workflows do you use to meet daily goals?
1. What excites you about working remotely over working in a traditional office environment?
1. How do you switch off from work?
1. Tell me about a time you recognized an opportunity for process improvement and how you brought that up to leadership.
1. What would you do if you have a piece of work that requires help from someone in a different time zone and they are not available?
1. How do you schedule/prioritize/stay motivated?
1. What is your default when you don't know what to do next?

Use video calls to interview and engage

Candidates need to be comfortable with video calls since they are a primary medium for communication in a remote role. At GitLab, we use Zoom to connect with candidates via video calls.

This GitLab Unfiltered video demonstrates how to conduct a remote interview process.

{{< youtube "tHThOsneFOY"}}